of other prominent leaders, one of whom would replace Brezhnev after his demise. This report helped the government shape its diplomatic approach towards the Soviet Union until Brezhnev's death in November 1982.

The R&AW report on the political situation in the Soviet Union decoded Brezhnev's achievements as well as his ruthlessness in eliminating potential competitors in the power game. The Indian agency estimated that Brezhnev had eliminated almost all the possible leaders from the next generation, such as Voronov, Shalepin, Mazurov, Shelest and Polyanski, all of whom he perceived as threats to his authoritarianism. Despite this, the Indian agency said, the old guard were no longer in complete control of Soviet policy. Brezhnev had at least introduced some new blood into the executive positions to decide the future of the Soviet Union. The report said:

Brezhnev's great achievement has been the transformation of top leadership without drama from a coalition of interests in 1964 to a fairly loyal group of junior men willing to accept his supremacy. This was accompanied by no interruption of the new rule of law in non-political matters, which obtains primacy in the country. Today, there are only three people born after Lenin's death in the top thirty-odd individuals who rule USSR. Most of the members of the cabinet were born during the second decade of this century and have been in power for an average of twenty-five years. The last ten years has seen a new willingness to discuss gaps in the Soviet practices in the sectors of technology, management and devolution of authority. The young men who will take over by 1985 would be those who grew up after 1945. Detailed speculation about their beliefs would be futile, except to say negatively that all ruling groups would be proud of the Soviet Union's status as a superpower